Perhaps he didn’t meet the best scholars. In India, Bernier ‘is simultaneously attentive and dismissive, curious and contemptuous’, writes philosopher Justin E.H. Smith, adding another nuance in noting that ‘his negative judgments flow from his status as a libertine materialist philosopher in the battle against superstition back home in Europe’.[7]

Bernier triumphantly concludes, ‘If the renowned sciences of the . . . Indies consisted of all the extravagant follies which I have detailed, mankind have indeed been deceived in the exalted opinion they have long entertained of their wisdom.’ This may have been a valid critique had Bernier arrived at it through an adequate understanding of the subject. Instead, he mostly illustrates the difficulties inherent in a dialogue between disparate intellectual traditions.

Bernier’s world view is familiar to us for its early modernity, humanism and materialistic ethos. He had his prejudices but he was also often remarkably clear-eyed. In Europe, his account fuelled the stereotype of ‘oriental despotisms’ among thinkers like James Mill, Hegel and Marx, who imagined Indians as unchanging, passive and superstitious.[8] Later, some others would see in his depiction the presence of ‘tolerance and coexistence of pluralistic subcultures’ in India.[9]

Bernier didn’t just travel through; for twelve years he worked and engaged with Indians with considerable openness. He wrote what is now a rare and insightful portrait of seventeenth-century India, decades before the arrival of European colonizers. In his account, India seems to be in a state of intellectual decay, uncreative and stunted, ill-prepared against the advancing power of Europe’s scientific method, mercantilism, scholarship and the nation-state model. He expressed fondness and affection for many people and things, but a good part of his account is an indictment of Indian society—though in ways that resonate aplenty with our own liberal assessments today.